Nicholas Kadunce

Plant Manager, Jennmar · Reedsville, West Virginia

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Runs a $90M+ profit center for Jennmar. Recruited into an open seat to build the plant's performance-management system. Accountable for safety, quality, delivery, cost, working capital, S&OP, the capital plan, and about 100 people. The operating system built at Reedsville now runs in all six plants of the division; plant results are reviewed with the division executive team every Monday. Lean Six Sigma Black Belt. B.S., Chemical Engineering.

Year one at Reedsville

Operating income up · Cost per ton **−15%** · Inventory **−27%**, **$3M+** working capital released · On-time delivery **97%** → **99%** · TRIR **4.2** → **1.6** · DART **3.3** → **0**

CORE COMPETENCIES

Operations and P&L P&L and Working Capital Management · S&OP and Demand Planning · Capital Planning and Business Cases · Safety Leadership (OSHA) · ISO 9001 Quality Systems

Operating System and People Daily Management Systems · Executive Operating Reviews · Financial Forecasting and Cost Control · Cross-Plant Standardization · Lean Six Sigma (Black Belt) · Succession Planning · Change Management

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Jennmar · Reedsville, WV — **January 2025 – Present**

Plant Manager

An open seat and an operating system to build.

Privately held, private-equity-backed global manufacturer of ground-control products for underground mining and tunneling; $1B+ revenue; one of six bolt plants in the division.

$90M+ P&L · ~100 PEOPLE ACROSS PRODUCTION, MAINTENANCE, QUALITY, SAFETY, SHIPPING, HR, AND INVENTORY · 7 DIRECT REPORTS · OWNS S&OP · ~25,000 TONS/YR · ~80 SKUS · 11 PROCESSES · 27 PRODUCTION ASSETS · TWO SHIFTS · REPORTS TO THE VP OF OPERATIONS

Accountable for safety, quality, delivery, cost, working capital, and the capital plan. Took the seat with a mandate to build the plant's performance-management system, make results visible to the executive team, and bring in lean manufacturing.

- **Improved operating income in year one**: cost per ton down **15%** despite inflation; inventory down **27%**, releasing **more than $3M of working capital**, with days on hand from 80 to 65.
- Raised on-time delivery from **97% to 99%** at a held 5-day lead time and brought **customer complaints to zero**. Established quality governance (automated tensile test logs, SPC by heat number, Pareto, tagged quarantine), since adopted at every plant in the division.
- Grew output **3.2%** with **about 10% less hourly labor** and **11% less overtime**. The levers were standard work, workflow balancing, automation, and a headcount model that sets staffing from the sales projection and OEE. **About $250K a year in process savings** validated by cost accountants.
- Cut the recordable injury rate from **TRIR 4.2 to 1.6** and **DART from 3.3 to zero**, with no citations, by moving safety to leading indicators: layered audits, near-miss reporting with root-cause removal, machine guarding that eliminates hazards, and dust collection upgrades.
- Built the **Daily Operations Review** (automated daily email and dashboard: safety, availability, inventory, sales to budget, quality, headcount, capex, lean) and a daily net-income **Financial Forecaster**. Demonstrated both to the executive team at the annual managers meeting, then rolled them out in person to **all six plants**; the executive team follows sales to budget and open safety actions through them. IT now owns the platform and is extending it company-wide.
- Proposed moving volume to a sister plant with capacity to spare when Reedsville ran over budget, a decision taken jointly with the VP of Operations. **Both plants met budget**; Reedsville's **overtime fell from 92 to 82 hours per employee biweekly** over four months and held after the volume returned. Relocated a piece of equipment to a sister plant, saving **$35K a year** in freight.
- Won approval for the **2026 capital plan, $900K across four projects**, led by a $750K integrated forging-and-assembly cell, the first of its kind in the company, projected to cut cycle time 45% with payback under three years; annual capital need fell from $1.4M to $0.9M.
- **Hired about 25 and promoted about 10**, including the production supervisor developed into superintendent as planned succession; installed supervisor standard work and refined the per-piece incentive, automating its administration. Accountable for stormwater and waste permits, with no notices of violation.
- Moved maintenance from reactive to planned with a CMMS rollout covering work orders, spares control, and maintenance analytics; **corrective work orders fell from 159 to 50 per month**.

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Eos Energy Enterprises · Turtle Creek, PA — December 2023 – December 2024

A public scale-up ramping against investor milestones.

Publicly traded US battery energy storage scale-up; 500 to 1,000 employees; revenue $16M in 2024 and $115M in 2025.

Operations Manager · June 2024 – December 2024

TWO PRODUCTION BUILDINGS · UP TO 240 TECHNICIANS, 11 SUPERVISORS, AND 6 TEAM LEADS · REPORTED TO THE SR. DIRECTOR OF OPERATIONS · DAILY OUTPUT REVIEW WITH THE EXECUTIVE TEAM

- Selected through a competitive process; started with one building (about 180 technicians) and took on the second when its manager left. **Met every investor performance milestone** while in the role, with no recordable injuries.
- Replaced a next-day count sheet with the **company's first hour-by-hour production dashboards**: OEE, gap analysis, and control charts.
- Cut **module assembly time from 46.5 to 20.5 minutes** by streamlining test and converting subassembly from batch to one-piece flow; subassembly rate up 41%, defects down 22%.
- Raised **BESS output from 0.5 to 2.2 units per day**, sustained, with Yamazumi balancing, takt alignment, and team workflows; **rework down 66%**.
- Recruited and trained a **40-person third shift in two months** that led the plant on OEE within a month. Hired about 100, promoted 8, and sustained a 12-per-shift headcount reduction after subassembly automation.

Quality Engineer · December 2023 – June 2024

- Built the **quality program from scratch**: defect codes, a QMS, control plans, test protocols, and internal audits toward ISO 9001; directed the daily work of six quality technicians.
- Wrote the specifications and test regimen for the next-generation module and BESS launch ahead of production; cut **testing cycle time about 60%** and **scrap defects 30%**; automated quality records and Pareto dashboards.

Messer Americas · Northeast Region (PA, WV, ME) — October 2022 – December 2023

Privately held industrial gas producer (Messer Group, about 4.4 billion euros in revenue).

Regional Production Engineer

FOUR AIR SEPARATION PLANTS ACROSS PA, WV, AND ME, ABOUT 80 EMPLOYEES · $400K PROJECT AND EXPENSE BUDGET · REGIONAL ENGINEERING ROLE WITH WEEKLY SITE TRAVEL

- Initiated and led the Krypton/Xenon production project: **output up 15% and $1M+ in annual revenue** validated by finance, with lower hydrocarbon concentration risk in the process. $1.1M in total validated project value.
- Led **15+ reliability and capital projects** across the region: **25 fewer downtime days per year**, lead times down about 30 days, and about $20K negotiated in vendor savings.
- Reorganized maintenance tools and spares at point of use with 5S and min/max levels by asset; the site teams owned the ideas and kept it running on their own.

Johnson Matthey · Smithfield, PA — September 2020 – October 2022

Global catalyst manufacturer headquartered in the UK; the plant produced heavy-duty diesel catalytic converters on a fully automated, high-mix line.

Production Team Shift Leader II · March 2022 – October 2022

- Ran the shift as acting supervisor: production timelines, safe practices, layered process audits, shift start and handover. **Plant OEE rose from 76% to 81.2%** in 2022 with zero lost-time and recordable injuries plant-wide.

Process Control Engineer · September 2020 – March 2022

- Owned setups and optimization of the automated line; **cycle time down 8%, defects down 4%**; a setup-parameter library removed 35 hours of annual changeover downtime; **$220K in savings** validated by the CI manager.

CREDENTIALS, RECOGNITION, AND EDUCATION

CERTIFICATIONS

Applied Agentic AI for Organizational Transformation · MIT Professional Education — Jul 2026

Lean Six Sigma Black Belt Professional · Six Sigma Global Institute — Apr 2026

OSHA 30-Hour — Jun 2025

Certified ScrumMaster (CSM) · Scrum Alliance — Nov 2024

ISO 9001 Lead Auditor training · Exemplar Global — Feb 2024

RECOGNITION

Cover feature, Metals & Mining Review · Oct 2026
Leadership Perspectives, "Operational Performance Builder"; author of "Building Operations that Deliver Results"; Certificate of Editorial Recognition

EMBRACE Country Champion, Efficiency (United States) · Messer Americas, for 2022 — Mar 2023

EDUCATION

B.S., Chemical Engineering · West Virginia University